Working Application Title: "Build now or die tomorrow: A Bondian approach to team development for attainable at-scale housing projects in Canada"

OR something like "Building the Build Now Waterloo Region living lab: Developing a national action partnership to create a community resource toolkit"

Abstract

BUILD NOW ...

LEIA'S JOBS:

- Who needs to be involved
- What are the key activities and what's the budget
- Knowledge mobilization plan

Overall Goal and Objectives (3/4 page – based on Cameron's example)

Since 2000, the price of a home in Canada has quadrupled with the average price now being around $700,000.[1] Canada's resultant and ongoing affordable housing crisis has had several cascading effects at the individual and interpersonal levels, as well as more broadly for society. Regarding the former, if the average household today were to buy the average house it is estimated that they would spend 60% of their disposable income on housing alone in some provinces,[2] children in families struggling with housing affordability can experience disrupted development and poorer educational outcomes,[3] and that those experiencing housing insecurity are more likely to experience exposure to communicable diseases and violence.[4] Concerning the latter, a lack of housing combined with poor public options can precipitate crowding and perpetuate cycles of poverty and crime,[5] and exacerbate economic inequality through reducing disposable income for lower socioeconomic classes to spend on other essentials such as food, education, and healthcare.[6] Ultimately, the Canadian Mortgage and Housing Corporation (CMHC) estimates that to restore housing affordability in Canada, an additional 3.5 million housing units are needed by 2030.[7]

At the same time, extant housing strategies in Canada have been panned for applying definitions of 'core housing need' that exclude people experiencing homelessness (PEH),[8] remaining behind on integrating 'missing middle' (i.e., medium-density housing such as townhouses, duplexes, mid-rise [4-8 storeys] apartments) solutions,[e.g., 9] and failing to adequately address regulatory obstacles.[5] Moreover, with recent affordable housing projects in cities such as Edmonton (AB), Coquitlam (BC), and Toronto (ON) reportedly being implemented by financialized corporations ostensibly run by private investment returns,[10] there is a need to offer municipalities across the country novel, typologically diverse (i.e., feature multiple types of housing options), community-oriented, and empirically-supported affordable/attainable housing strategies/solutions. Our partnership will answer the question: "*How can Canadian municipalities implement an effective evidence-based, community-oriented housing strategy that provides typically diverse attainable/affordable homes at-scale for their residents?*" To achieve this goal, we will pursue the three following objectives over the next three years:

O1: strengthen the impact and vision of our BUILD NOW: Waterloo Region (BNWR) team via 'city sprint' meetings to co-create an initial 'Build Now': Practical Attainable Housing Solutions toolkit for municipalities.

O2: present our initial 'Build Now': Practical Attainable Housing Solutions toolkit to audiences across Canada and recruit new members to be involved in the revising and continued development of the toolkit.

O3: with our expanded and national team, finalize the co-creation of an open access 'Build Now': Practical Attainable Housing Solutions toolkit that municipalities across Canada, and internationally, may to address their local housing issue(s).

Originality, Significance and Expected Contribution (1/2 page – based on Cameron's example)

There is significant concern among policymakers and practitioners in Canada that the housing situation is worsening due to incrementalist approaches, bureaucratic obstacles, misaligned government roles, and a lack of ingenuity, resulting in a dearth of effective and timely solutions.[11] Exacerbating these worries are the continued demographic pressures contributing to increasing housing demand. Annually, reports from recent years have estimated that >800,000 foreign students (study permit holders),[12] >700,000 temporary workers,[13] and >360,000 new immigrants[14] move to Canada. The BUILD NOW: Waterloo Project represents a first-of-its-kind community-led housing initiative that will produce a typologically

diverse community of attainable housing units.[15] This project will leverage our team's existing relationship with the Build Now project in the Region of Waterloo to build [something about Canada's first academic-public-developer partnership dedicated to the implementation and evaluation of a 10,000 unit attainable housing project]. Through strengthening our BNWR team in this project, we will create a first-of-its-kind, step-by-step attainable housing solution guide, based on a current project and national expert team's input, for practitioners and policymakers. The development of this toolkit will also serve as a platform for future research regarding the co-op and mixed housing schemes and various sociopolitical, economic, environmental, and health indicators and topics among our team members.

Theoretical Background (1.75-2 pages – based on Cameron's example)

According to several metrics and indicators Canada is facing both a housing and affordable housing crisis.[16] In addition to the estimated 3.5 million housing units that CMHC has suggested are needed by 2030,[7] the Royal Bank of Canada (RBC) has observed that ~60,000 social housing units need to be created annually to meet demand.[17] Subsequently, RBC has recommended more investment in greater housing mix (e.g., affordable, student, rental apartment housing) and the implementation of legislative supports for municipalities using best (e.g., via Ontario's $1.2-billion Building Faster Fund).[17] Recent discussions regarding the creation of effective solutions and strategies from public sector,[16] industry,[18] academic,[19] and nongovernmental[20] actors have variously argued in favour of the need for efficiency and responsiveness, improved multi-sector alignment or coordination, and the further diversification and development the of current housing mix.

Current ineffective attempts to address the current housing situation have led to several compounding issues for Canadians of many backgrounds. For instance, in the nearer term, Canada's housing crisis has contributed significant financial strain to families (e.g., sacrificing basic needs like food and clothes),[21] reduced homeownership rates and household/family formation,[22] and worsened reports of quality of life and well-being among younger cohorts.[23] In instances where there is social housing available but is of low-quality, there are several compounded social, economic, and health impacts that can affect residents. As of 2015, approximately 30% of Canadian households live in such substandard housing or core housing need[24] where these environments have long been associated with an increased risk of asthma,[25] injury risks,[26] and exposure to environmental toxins such as lead.[27]

In the intermediate term, inadequate housing construction and provision has produced waitlists for affordable and subsidized accommodations that are unrealistic for applicants. Illustratively, in 2022, roughly 245,900 households had been placed on social/affordable housing waitlists, with close to two-thirds ultimately waiting two years or longer or placement.[28] In Canada's largest cities the waitlist times are reaching unprecedented levels with reported waits of 15 years for a 3+-bedroom in Toronto[29] and over five years for a rental unit in Ottawa.[30] In 2025, similar trends are now being documented even in mid-sized cities like Windsor, Ontario where estimated wait times for social housing are five-six years long.[31] In the long-term, with fewer younger Canadian households able to buy into the housing market and achieve homeownership, and subsequently build wealth but, concurrently, Canada has the highest household debt to disposable income ratio among G7 nations.[32] In response to these many factors, emerging paradigms have suggested that investments in and solutions for housing in Canada need to more thoroughly engage with housing mix, especially as it concerns social/public stock.

Most of Canada's social housing stock was built by the federal government over six decades ago, and has seen its level of production continue to decline since the 1980s.[33] While Canada's National Housing Strategy (NHS) was passed in 2017 with the mandate of investing

$78.5 billion into housing across the country, advocates suggest that the NHS does little to address Canada's urgent need to build more social housing—social housing in Canada currently represents just 3.5% (655,000) of total housing stock.[34] As a result, social housing projects in Canada ostensibly are funded and implemented in a manner according with which communities are able to support them (see Table X for overview of select ongoing projects across Canada).

Table X. Overview of Select Ongoing Social & Affordable Housing Projects in Canada

Location	Project	Housing Details	Goal(s)
[35]Canmore, AB (Pop: 14,370)	Canmore Community Housing	119 rental units 156 homeownership units *Workforce, community populations*	Re-zoning of target lands to residential land, attract private investment to community
[36]Edmonton, AB (Pop: 1.1 mil.)	Ambrose Place Supportive Housing Model	42 permanent supportive housing units *Homeless Indigenous populations*	Support co-ownership model with local Indigenous charity
[35]Gibsons, BC (Pop: 4,758)	Shaw Road Apartments	21 market rentals 19 non-market rentals *Workforce, family, senior populations*	Lead community engagement, support for local workforce/ economy families
[15,37]Region of Waterloo, ON (Pop: 700,000)	BUILD NOW: Waterloo Region	10,000 "missing middle" units[38] (e.g., apartments, townhomes) *Family, lower-income populations*	Mixed ownership (70%) and rental (30%) community development model
[39]Toronto, ON (Pop: 3 mil.)	Housing Now Initiative	918 units (incl. 612 rent-geared-to-income & market rent-controlled co-ops) *Housing insecure populations*	Mixed co-op and market ownership building model, resident-run board of directors
[40]Montreal, QC (Pop: 1.8 mil.)	Le Christin	114 units *Housing insecure populations*	Socially diverse housing for vulnerable populations

The BUILD NOW: Waterloo Region project is a $500-million initiative led by Habitat for Humanity which will build 10,000 new in the region by 2030.[41] Of the existing social housing and affordable housing programs, none feature i) a combined housing stock and production scale similar, or ii) diverse housing mix, equal to the BUILD NOW: Waterloo Region project. Regarding the former, the BUILD NOW: Waterloo Region project is a modern version of Canada's wartime housing program.[38] The project explicitly seeks to build affordable units at-scale through providing 10,000 units of 'missing middle' homes across the Region,[37] and is will work with a host of partners to ensure the long-term common interest of housing in the community.[38] With respect to the latter and housing mix, as alluded to, BUILD NOW: Waterloo Region will engage the community, private and public sector actors, and not-for-profit organizations[37] to help with ensuring specific housing is provided for populations across a wide spectrum of incomes and needs. Notably, the project has identified designing housing for vulnerable populations (e.g. supportive and Indigenous housing), moderate income households, and larger/multigenerational households.[41] Ultimately, this approach will result in the construction of 10,000 affordable or attainable housing units that will remain as such in perpetuity; feature a mix of tenure (30% Rental, 70% ownership); and use of local contractors to engage and build capacity in the local non-profit and co-operative housing sector.[41]

Addressing the challenge of creating affordable, suitable, and sustainable home ownership in Canada requires a fundamental shift in how we think about and build housing. The Future Cities Institute proposes a world-class Living Lab in Waterloo Region to advance a transformational affordable housing model. Through interdisciplinary research, experiential learning, and local and international partnerships, the Build Now Living Lab will assess and amplify the economic, health, sustainability, technological and societal impacts of community-led housing — creating local solutions with global relevance. The Build Now Living Lab directly addresses a nationally urgent, socially complex challenge with the potential for

real and lasting impact. It proposes a novel model of interdisciplinary, data-informed, and community-embedded research within a large-scale real-world development. It brings together academia, civil society, industry, and government in a true partnership, positioning our Region as a global leader in housing innovation. The Living Lab will provide the evidence, tools, and scalable models needed to fundamentally reshape how communities are built—transforming housing from a source of crisis to a platform for prosperity, well-being, and sustainability. The aim of our project is to build and strengthen our existing Region of Waterloo Build Now team into a national collaboration that will develop a novel 'Build Now' housing toolkit for municipalities to employ for building attainable housing at-scale in their communities.

Methodological Approach and Timeline (1.75-2 pages – based on Cameron's example)

O1 (May/26-April/27): *strengthen the impact and vision of our Region of Waterloo Build Now (BNWR) team via 'city sprint' meetings to co-create an initial 'Build Now': Practical Attainable Housing Solutions toolkit for municipalities*. At the outset of this work, the Project Direction (PD) will write ethics applications to the University of Waterloo Office of Research for all team meeting, data collection, and knowledge mobilization (KmB) activities contained within this project, as well as create a partnership Data Management Plan. The PD will work with the Co-Applicants and Collaborators on the BNWR team to establish working groups to guide this project and its component objectives.

O2 (May/27-April/28): *present our initial 'Build Now': Practical Attainable Housing Solutions toolkit to audiences across Canada and recruit new members to be involved in the revising and continued development of the toolkit*. After revising our Regional team's collaborative and vision statement, we will seek to build a nationally representative Build Now collective through presenting our work and recruiting members at multiple planning, public administration, housing, and industry conferences/meeting. Specifically, our team will be represented at the National Conference of the Canadian Institute of Planners (CIP) 2026/2027, The Ontario Professional Planners Institute (OPPI) 2026/2027 annual conference, the International Conference on Sustainable Urban Development and Spatial Planning (ICSUDSP) in Montreal (Aug 05/2026), the International Conference on Urban Landscape and Urban Planning (ICULUP) in Vancouver (May 20/2027), Federation of Canadian Municipalities annual conference 2026/2027, Canadian Association of Municipal Administrators annual conference 2026/2027, and the Canadian Home Builders' Association annual conference 2026/2027.

(O3: May/28-April/29): *with our expanded and national team, finalize the co-creation of an open access 'Build Now': Practical Attainable Housing Solutions toolkit that municipalities across Canada, and internationally, may to address their local housing issue(s)*.

European Network of Living Labs (EnoLL): FCI has an emerging partnership with ENoLL, an international non-profit association that promotes and the Living Lab concept around the world by facilitating knowledge exchange, joint actions, and project partnerships. Together with CEE's International Strategic Initiatives team, FCI will identify international student learning experiences (e.g., co-op terms) with ENoLL members and will reinforce UWaterloo's global

presence by participating F’25 – S’28 in workshops and training opportunities for the duration of the funding.

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Previous SSHRC Funding (1 page – based on Cameron's example ... looks like can include all team members)

Budget Justification (2 pages & tied to the objectives above – based on Cameron's example)

To successfully achieve objective 1

Description of Formal Partnership (1/2 page intro – based on Cameron's example)

The development of our national Build Now team will begin with ...

The Partnership Approach (1/2 page – based on Cameron's example)

Partnership Intellectual Leadership (1/3 page intro – based on Cameron's example)

Integration of Partner Expertise (1/3 page intro – based on Cameron's example)

Addressing Anticipated Partnership Challenges (1/3 page intro – based on Cameron's example)

Benefits to Partner Organizations (1/2 page intro – based on Cameron's example)

Potential Partner Organizations (1/2 page intro – based on Cameron's example)

Other Contributors (1/2 page intro – based on Cameron's example)

Participants Involvement (2 pages)

Contribution to the proposed research: 35%; Percentage of research time spent on the project: 60%.

Contribution to the proposed research: 30%, Percentage of research time spent on the project: 20%.

Training and Mentoring (1 page)

Research Methods and Theories:

Research Communication:

Knowledge Mobilization:

Digital Literacy:

Data Management and Analysis:

Interdisciplinary Research:

Teamwork:

Workshop Facilitation:

Knowledge Mobilization Plan (2 pages max)

Outputs of the proposed research project are intended for several audiences, namely those involved in city planning, housing, and land development decision-making processes. To this, end, elected officials (e.g., mayors, councillors, MPPs/MPs), urban design practitioners, community and public health practitioners, housing developers, and researchers (e.g., housing, community development, civil engineering) will be the primary targets for our knowledge mobilization (KMb) plans. Traditional research outputs in the form of academic articles (**O2-O3**) will be the first focus of our KMb plan. Together, the Research Team will undertake a qualitative studying the development and formalization of our toolkit (**O2**), and then complete a qualitative process evaluation of the partnership development (**O3**), which together will result in two manuscripts being published in peer-reviewed academic journals. Leading interdisciplinary social science and housing journals will be targeted for our publications including *Cities* (5-year IF: 7.5) and *Housing Studies* (5-year IF: 3.9). Evidence briefs covering and access to the developed toolkit will also be provided through our Team's free-to-use housing policy platform (www.CivicInquire.com). Beyond traditional KMb plans pertaining to academic output, we will also leverage two additional strategies: i) international living labs partnerships and ii) local community engagement.

International Living Labs Partnerships

Our Living Lab leverages partnerships between community, government, and industry to foster collaboration in housing innovation. With the Waterloo Region Community Foundation (WRCF), we will co-host four City Sprints, a two-day design sprint developed by FCI where invited partners problem-solve a specific bottleneck. City Sprints will aim to develop solution prototypes funded through a $30K funding commitment from WRCF (no GFF funding ask).

Second, FCI leadership meets with Build Now partners bi-weekly to ensure effective Partnership Engagement. Our Build Now partners have connected us to many opportunities to advance FCI impact in our community (in-kind external partner contribution; no GFF ask).

Finally, Waterloo's global presence will be reinforced through our partnership with ENoLL, the world-leading international organization that helps Living Labs around the world incorporate best practices in research and management to expand their impact. We are working with CEE's International Strategic Initiatives team to identify co-op students work opportunities with ENoLL members. Total GFF ask $7,500 (matched 1:1 GFF:FCI) to participate in ENoLL training opportunities and bring world-class expertise to Waterloo.

Community Engagement

The research and training undertaken by the Living Lab is embedded in inclusive community engagement and co-creation: community engagement is foundational to research and knowledge mobilization, which ensures the integration of diverse voices. Finally, our team is committed to open data and the democratization of the tools and recommendations that are generated by this project. Municipalities, especially low-resource municipalities, deserve to have access to world-class tools and information we will develop and synthesize to their own city building work.

The dissemination of findings to the municipal governments in Beira and Puri will primarily rely on the professional networks created in Objective Four via the Steering Committees in each respective city. In order to support the city-specific knowledge mobilization activities in this project, the research team will work with the city-specific Steering Committees to establish cross-sectoral stakeholder networks within each city to translate SDG-VLRs into action.